

# WHAT DOES HEBREWS 6:4-6 MEAN?

When it comes to this passage, there is controversy regarding its meaning.

4 **For it is impossible for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost,**

5 **And have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come,**

6 **if they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put *him* to an open shame.**

But there are two basic thoughts as to what this passage is trying to convey. The first thought is considered very scary by some people. And I think that because they are scared of this though, they attempt to prove it wrong at any cost.

**#1: You can lose your salvation.** This passage is stating the fact that if you were once a partaker of the Holy Ghost (a born again believer) and you fall away, you are not able to come back and be born again, again.

## Issues with this interpretation:

**A:** This would mean that you can lose your salvation. That would make God's promise in John 3:16 no longer valid. It would make God a liar.

**Counter:** No it doesn't. John 3:16 says that whosoever believes, gets everlasting life. So if someone dies and does not believe, they don't get eternal life—regardless of if they believed at one point or not.

**#2: You can't lose your salvation.** This verse is speaking of those who have witnessed the Holy Spirit working, but are not truly born again. These are immature, weak Christians or not Christians at all.

## Issues with this interpretation:

**A:** How can a person taste of the Holy Ghost without being a born-again believer?

**Counter:** A person can see and feel what the Holy Spirit is doing, they can partake in the experience, it doesn't mean they are a born-again believer. Either way, this could just be speaking of Christians that back-slide.

**B:** Even if this only means that they have seen and felt the Holy Ghost in action, why does it say that they would need to crucify Jesus again?

**C:** If this is about Christians that have just back-slidden, why does it say that it is impossible for them to "renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh"? A person only needs Christ to be crucified when they become a born-again believer.

## HYPOTHETICAL WARNING?

4 For *it is impossible* for those who were once **enlightened**, and **have tasted of the heavenly gift**, and **were made partakers of the Holy Ghost**,

5 And **have tasted the good word of God**, and **the powers of the world to come**,

6 if they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they **crucify to themselves the Son of God** afresh, and put *him* to an open shame.

I cannot see how someone sees this as hypothetical. It is dealing with a lot of real things. For example, look at all the red highlighted above.

There is nothing about this passage that would make someone think it is hypothetical. Unless someone has a preconceived idea, and this passage goes against it.

This passage's message is repeated again in Hebrews 10:26. So with it being a warning put down twice, I cannot see how someone still thinks it's hypothetical.

## ENGLISH BREAK DOWN

So, if we break this apart in English, you get something that looks like this:

4 **For it is impossible** for those who were once **enlightened**, and **have tasted of the heavenly gift**, and **were made partakers of the Holy Ghost**,

5 **And have tasted the good word of God**, and **the powers of the world to come**,

6 **if they shall fall away**, to **renew them again unto repentance**; seeing they **crucify to themselves the Son of God** afresh, and put *him* to an open shame.

The **red text** says that it is impossible for a certain group of people (these people are described with great detail in the **blue text**), and the **green text** finishes by saying it is impossible for these people to renew them again unto repentance. The **purple text** is just the explanation as to why this statement is true.

From what I have found, this is the correct way of reading this passage. And from reading this passage, I can only see it warning of born-again believers falling away from the faith.

# GREEK BREAK DOWN

Here are some words defined in the original Greek according to Strong's Concordance<sup>D1</sup>. Just in case you think you might be getting the wrong idea because of some wrong word or modern definition.

4 For *it is impossible* [102 [e]; unable, powerless] for those who were *once* [530 [e]; once, once for all] *enlightened* [5461 [e]; to shine, give light], and *have tasted* [1089 [e]; to taste, eat] of the heavenly gift, and were made *partakers* [3353 [e]; sharing in] of the Holy Ghost,

5 And *have tasted* [1089 [e]; to taste, eat] the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come,

6 if they shall fall away, *to renew* [340 [e]; to renew] them again unto *repentance* [3341 [e]; change of mind, repentance]; seeing they *crucify* [388 [e]; to crucify again] to themselves the Son of God afresh, and *put him to an open shame* [3856 [e]; to set forth as an example; usage: make a public example of].

That is just to show that the translation is accurate, and you are reading words correctly and accurately in English. You can see the definition of the words and just see that the words used are correct.

Some people point out that the verses talk about a person who has only "tasted of" the heavenly gift or good word of God. Some might say that they have only tasted of Christianity, and are not actually true born-again Christians. The issue with this is that the definition of "have tasted" here is "to taste" or "eat." This could very well be speaking of a person who has eaten of Christianity. That doesn't sound quite as much like an unbeliever.

## WHO ARE THEY?

Who are being spoken of in this passage? Let's see what it says:

4 For *it is impossible* for those *who were once enlightened*, and have *tasted of the heavenly gift*, and *were made partakers of the Holy Ghost*,

5 And have *tasted the good word of God*, and *the powers of the world to come*,

6 if they shall fall away, *to renew them again unto repentance*; seeing they *crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh*, and *put him to an open shame*.

Let's tally up what we have here. The persons in question here is described as:

**who were once enlightened:** When it comes to the word "enlightened" here, a born-again believer is described as having enlightened understanding in Ephesians 1:18. So this could definitely mean a born-again believer. However, this isn't the proof of a born-again believer—although I think it kind of strange for the Bible to call a lost person "enlightened."

**tasted of the heavenly gift:** What is the heavenly gift? When examining the New Testament, you find the word "gift" is mostly something to do with salvation. Out of the 38 mentions of the word "gift" in the New Testament, around 20 are talking about, or are closely related with salvation. The others are clearly talking about something

completely different. Here, in Hebrews, it would seem to be the only place where the Bible speaks of a "gift" in a confusing way. The phrase "heavenly gift" likely is referring to salvation.

**were made partakers of the Holy Ghost:** Partaker in this passage means to "share in." Basically to have a "share in" the Holy Ghost—or in this case—a person once had a "share in" the Holy Ghost. From the way I see it, you have to twist things quite a bit to see a person that shares in the Holy Ghost as an unbeliever. I see this verse as extremely detailed and specific.

**tasted the good word of God:** The Bible is the word of God, and it makes sense for that to be what this is referring to. This doesn't prove that this person is a born-again believer, as many unbelievers read the Bible.

**the powers of the world to come:** I do not know what this is exactly referring to, but I assume it has something to do with the hopeful looking forward to heaven and the new earth, and God's power throughout all. If this is the case, an unbeliever would not be looking forward to the afterlife.

How would you describe a born-again believer better? Would replacing all this with the phrase "born-again believer" change your mind? This verse doesn't say that these people are born-again believers, but from what I see, it describes them.

In the end, this is what we know about this person, they were someone: **who were once enlightened, tasted of the heavenly gift, were made partakers of the Holy Ghost, tasted the good word of God**, and tasted of **the powers of the world to come**.

I see this as referring to a born-again Christian. I think it's a huge stretch to say this is describing an unbeliever.

## THE JEWISH PERSPECTIVE

One must remember that this passage is addressed to Jewish Christians. These born-again believers are struggling and seem to be in danger of falling away (or backsliding if one does not believe that a Christian can fall away).

From what I found<sup>F1</sup>, the Jewish viewpoint is that this passage is a warning to Jewish Christians not to turn back to Judaism. It is a warning for Jews not to forsake the faith and reject Christ, and to remain strong in their faith.

From what I found, they see Hebrews as arguing for Christ's sacrifice being superior to all others. They see this passage as a warning to born-again believers not to fall back into Judaism. They saw these verses as a warning not to reject the savior.

Most sources I found, stated that the Jewish Christian community saw Hebrews 6 as a warning to born-again believers not to back-slide. They would not deal with what it means to have to re-crucify Christ.

# CONTEXT

It is possible that I am taking this passage out of context, so just for good measure, I'll give you the previous chapter, and all of chapter 6 to read.

The context is speaking of born-again believers that are immature in their faith. Then it feeds right into chapter six saying that we ought to leave the "principles of the doctrine of Christ" and "go on unto perfection." It says that this is what "we do, if God permit."

That's where the passage in question starts.

Go ahead and read chapter five and six. And if you got the time, go read the entire book of Hebrews.

## HEBREWS CHAPTER 5

- 1 For every high priest taken from among men is ordained for men in things pertaining to God, that he may offer both gifts and sacrifices for sins:
- 2 Who can have compassion on the ignorant, and on them that are out of the way; for that he himself also is compassed with infirmity.
- 3 And by reason hereof he ought, as for the people, so also for himself, to offer for sins.
- 4 And no man taketh this honour unto himself, but he that is called of God, as was Aaron.
- 5 So also Christ glorified not himself to be made an high priest; but he that said unto him, Thou art my Son, to day have I begotten thee.
- 6 As he saith also in another place, Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchisedec.
- 7 Who in the days of his flesh, when he had offered up prayers and supplications with strong crying and tears unto him that was able to save him from death, and was heard in that he feared;
- 8 Though he were a Son, yet learned he obedience by the things which he suffered;
- 9 And being made perfect, he became the author of eternal salvation unto all them that obey him;
- 10 Called of God an high priest after the order of Melchisedec.
- 11 Of whom we have many things to say, and hard to be uttered, seeing ye are dull of hearing.
- 12 For when for the time ye ought to be teachers, ye have need that one teach you again which be the first principles of the oracles of God; and are become such as have need of milk, and not of strong meat.
- 13 For every one that useth milk is unskilful in the word of righteousness: for he is a babe.
- 14 But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age, even those who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil.

## HEBREWS CHAPTER 6

- 1 Therefore leaving the principles of the doctrine of Christ, let us go on unto perfection; not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works, and of faith toward God,
- 2 Of the doctrine of baptisms, and of laying on of hands, and of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment.
- 3 And this will we do, if God permit.
- 4 **For it is impossible for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost,**
- 5 **And have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come,**

6 if they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put *him* to an open shame.

7 For the earth which drinketh in the rain that cometh oft upon it, and bringeth forth herbs meet for them by whom it is dressed, receiveth blessing from God:

8 But that which beareth thorns and briers is rejected, and is nigh unto cursing; whose end is to be burned.

9 But, beloved, we are persuaded better things of you, and things that accompany salvation, though we thus speak.

10 For God is not unrighteous to forget your work and labour of love, which ye have shewed toward his name, in that ye have ministered to the saints, and do minister.

11 And we desire that every one of you do shew the same diligence to the full assurance of hope unto the end:

12 That ye be not slothful, but followers of them who through faith and patience inherit the promises.

13 For when God made promise to Abraham, because he could swear by no greater, he sware by himself,

14 Saying, Surely blessing I will bless thee, and multiplying I will multiply thee.

15 And so, after he had patiently endured, he obtained the promise.

16 For men verily swear by the greater: and an oath for confirmation is to them an end of all strife.

17 Wherein God, willing more abundantly to shew unto the heirs of promise the immutability of his counsel, confirmed it by an oath:

18 That by two immutable things, in which it was impossible for God to lie, we might have a strong consolation, who have fled for refuge to lay hold upon the hope set before us:

19 Which hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and stedfast, and which entereth into that within the veil;

20 Whither the forerunner is for us entered, even Jesus, made an high priest for ever after the order of Melchisedec.

# SOURCES

Written by Lanthano on April 20, 2024

## GREEK BREAK DOWN

[D1] Bible Hub, with parallel Greek, Strong's numbers, and definitions (link going to Hebrews 6:4): <https://biblehub.com/text/hebrews/6-4.htm>

## THE JEWISH PERSPECTIVE

[F1] What does Hebrews 6 mean from the Jewish perspective?:

<https://enduringword.com/bible-commentary/hebrews-6/>;

[https://www.blueletterbible.org/comm/guzik\\_david/study-guide/hebrews/hebrews-6.cfm](https://www.blueletterbible.org/comm/guzik_david/study-guide/hebrews/hebrews-6.cfm)